THE KHALISTANI HENCHMEN



***Outfit*: ISYF, International Sikh Youth Federation**

Leader: *Lakhbir Singh Rode*

Plot: *Use Sukh Bikhariwal's gang for targeted killings of anti-Khalistan activists in Punjab, also to courier drone-delivered arms, ammunition, drugs in Amritsar and Gurdaspur*



Outfit: **Babbar Khalsa International**

Leader: Wadhawa Singh Babbar

Plot: Another instance of the pact between Khalistanis and gangsters. The ageing Babbar and his ISI masters have sheltered gangster Harvinder Rinda (left), who's now in Lahore. Use Punjab-based gangs for smuggling arms, targeted killings and attacks



Outfit: **Khalistan Commando Force**

Leader: Paramjit Panjwar

Plot: Uses the network of Rinda, its own network as well as smaller gangsters in the border areas of Punjab to keep up a busy calendar of smuggling, highway robbery and contract killings. Arms, ammunition, drugs...the gangs come in handy as couriers for all



Leader: **Kamaljit Singh Chauhan**

Based in Toronto

Plot: Has a network of gangster modules stretching all the way from Punjab to Canada. He uses Punjab-based gangs as couriers for drugs procured from Pakistan. Eventually, the trail of supply reaches all the way to North America

arrests or bullets. Capt. Amarinder Singh's tenure as chief minister saw a real crackdown. Eight gangsters were gunned down in encounters, among them Vicky Grounder, Prema Lahoria and Jaipal. But that only aided a sort of evolution. Many gangsters shifted their base outside, moving to Canada, Armenia, Dubai and Pakistan. And newer faces took their place in the world of crime—brasher, hungrier, swimming deeper in the global networks. Besides traditional gangland sport like robbery, abduction, extortion, contract killings, land-grabbing and the liquor trade, the arc of their bullets now defines the limits of a whole set of globalised activities. Everything from Punjab's thriving music and movie scene to drug and arms trafficking, and from kabaddi to Khalistani militancy has their imprimatur. They are like a free-lance army that provides an easy workforce to Khalistani groups and drug lords operating from abroad.

Investigations in the past five years have revealed that Khalistani militants based out of Lahore, Pakistan—such as Lakhbir Singh Rode, Paramjit Panjwar, Wadhawa Singh Babbar and Ranjeet Singh Neeta—have been working closely with gangsters to push arms, ammunition and drugs, besides controlling some of their investments in the entertainment industry. Intelligence agencies believe Bhagat Brar, Canada-based son of Lakhbir Rode, uses a clique of gangsters to extort money from Punjabi singers and movie stars—much like the D-Company shadowed Bollywood in the '80s-90s. Many Punjabi stars have been pictured with Bhagat and other gangsters while on tour to Canada. Last year, the Mohali police cracked down on two music companies, Thug Life and Gold Media, which they said were directly run by gangsters abroad—the Davinder Bambiha gang was said to be investing extortion money in them.

In 2018, singer-cum-actor Parmish Verma was shot at in Mohali by Dilpreet Singh Dalhan's gang for refusing to pay extortion money. Dalhan, part of the Bambiha clique, had once also threatened singer-cum-actor Gippy Grewal.

GUNS AND ROSES

What has brought about this strange marriage? An A-list star of Punjabi music told INDIA TODAY that because of its new global appeal, it's become very expensive to make quality videos to reach out to this market. "The gangs help singers recover money from producers, music companies; at times, they fund the videos...with black money," he says. There's a deeper social logic at play. Says a top Punjabi actor: "They may be gangsters now, but often come from the same social circles, some of them would have been college mates. Sadly, artistes are unable to draw the line." Thus it comes about that every gangster has his own favourite singer or actor, depending on old association, regional affiliation or plain utility.

This association has seeped back into Punjabi pop culture, leaving its mark on the entire oeuvre. Over the years, movies and songs legitimising the gun cult, Jatt machismo and gangsters as Robinhoods or style icons flooded the market—which now spans the diaspora in Europe, US, UK, Canada, Southeast Asia, Australia and New Zealand. The idea of a 'rebel' is laced with a political frisson in these parts, and that segues all too easily into a kind of latent militant consciousness, left over from the old Khalistan spirit. Even Akal Takht jathedar Giani Harpreet Singh advocated recently that every Sikh keep licensed weapons "because the time that is coming, and the circumstances that are going to prevail, demand it". He was criticised for his words, but it revealed the edginess prevailing in Punjab.